

Early works

Pärt continued his musical education at the Tallinn Music Middle School and from 1958 at the Tallinn Conservatory, at the same time working as a sound producer for Estonian public radio. While still a student, he wrote his first major orchestral work, *Nekrolog*, dedicated to victims of the Holocaust.

The first piece by an Estonian composer to use the 12-tone serial technique, it was denounced by the Soviet authorities. Undeterred, Pärt continued exploring avant-garde styles throughout the 1960s, and developed a sort of musical collage technique, incorporating a variety of Modernist ideas. However, he felt that he had still to find his own musical language. The turning point came in 1972. That year saw two major changes in his personal life: he got married, and he converted from Lutheranism to the Orthodox Church. This prompted him to take a break from composing, and to study medieval and Renaissance music, and more importantly the choral music of the Orthodox liturgy.

Pärt's studies elicited a radical change in his musical approach. He abandoned the complexity and intellectualism of his previous music to create an austere and almost static sound-world. Although the simplicity of this style bore some similarities to the American minimalist composers, in his idiosyncratic technique, which he called "tintinnabuli," he had found his unique personal voice (see [box](#)). After early works in this style, including perhaps his best-known composition, *Spiegel im Spiegel* (1978), he has written mainly sacred works inspired by his Orthodox Christian faith, or with a spiritual theme.